

+CO Creative Coding

AI's Hidden Water Footprint

According to the Swissinfo article «How AI data centers risk straining Switzerland's water resources» by Sara Ibrahim, the official data on water consumption remains scarce. However, the International Energy Agency estimates current demand at around 560 billion liters per year, which could escalate to 1,200 billion liters by 2030—a volume equivalent to the annual water needs of roughly ten million households.

These numbers hit a sore spot, especially when thinking about the impact that all of this could have on us. Therefore, the topic seems very relevant and we wanted to raise awareness about it through our project.

We did a lot of research and were flooded with news articles but as already mentioned at the beginning, not much of the data is open to the public. This brought up even more questions and left us with uncertainty not only about the topic but about the future as well.

So we started where most of us started at the rise of AI: ChatGPT. For most of us it is a helpful tool to solve our “problems”. A lot of us use it daily and most of the time we don't think about the impact of a single question. So I've made it my mission to write down random questions and incorporate them into my code. As time goes on, the questions become more and more serious and the water slowly turns brown, in order to draw attention to the water pollution caused by data center cooling. To reinforce this shift, I've added a fitting audio track that emphasizes the gravity of the issue and creates a specific, tense atmosphere. Ultimately, this leads to the central question: Is there actually enough water?

Going from there, we wanted to incorporate the videos in which politicians were interviewed on this important topic and also showing how much information there is to it all. We layered the videos, cut them together and tried to capture the maze of information, disinformation and total confusion in a code. There are glitches and there are errors, all of which, in a way, show that the topic is difficult to grasp.

I think we were able to get our point across, so I'm happy with the result. It was also great to work with someone on the team who is in a completely different program. This enriched our work and opened the door to new approaches. All in all, it was a great experience and I'm looking forward to more coding in the future!